

# DOOMed To Succeed

Be afraid, be very, very afraid

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Back in 1995, we first heard the name *DOOM*. The game actually had 'VGA' graphics—the word VGA inspired awe, and was spoken in a hushed tone back then. Most PCs were too 'underpowered' to play this game, so a few of us dashed over to a friend's place—he had just bought a 'fast' 486-SX, running at all of 40 MHz. As he fired up the game, our jaws dropped in amazement.

More colours than you could count, finely detailed graphics, a bob effect that simulated walking, superb weapon models, the list was endless. Then there was the environment itself—the mountains of Mars could only be described as achingly beautiful.

In short, it was a revolution—a whole bunch of never-seen-before features packed into a single game. It was the sole reason for thousands of people to upgrade our systems.

Gaming has come a long way since then, but no other title has managed to evoke the same reactions as *DOOM*.

With its latest game, id has finally dumped the old-school run-and-gun gameplay that it fathered, in favour of a more personal interaction with your deepest fears. A classic survival-horror shooter, it tells the tale of how all hell breaks loose (literally!) within minutes of you arriving at a Martian military base.

The game feels like living in a movie—steam pipes hiss, metal creaks, and monsters lunge out at exactly preordained points. FPS evolution has taken two distinct paths: the classic shooter with waves of monsters coming at you from everywhere, and the game with "cinematic quality" graphics and surround sound.

Another significant change is the better AI—zombies with guns will use available cover to pop out and take pot-shots at you. They are still not up to the level of *Half-Life*'s marines, though. For one, they are predictable, and they have not given up their kamikaze rush.

But where would a horror game be without its dark corners and flickering lights? *DOOM 3*'s graphics aren't eye-popping, for the simple reason that there are very few machines around that can actually run the game at ultra-high resolutions.

Yes, when id lists the minimum requirements for the game, it's lying through its teeth.

Nonetheless, you can get an idea of what to expect when you see effects such as shadows being cast in real-time. Expect to see some remarkable



results a few years from now, when other developers bring out their games based on the *DOOM 3* engine, and the hardware to actually run them has become more common. Is *DOOM 3* worth the upgrade, like *DOOM* was back in 1995? We don't think so! It's good, but not that good.

The game will genuinely scare you at times. It's a classic entertainer. It's a trendsetter. But it's certainly not revolutionary. *Far Cry* brought with it the great outdoors, *DOOM 3* brings in amazing lighting and graphical effects, and *Half-Life 2* is expected to provide realistic physics and tough AI. The tools for making the next wave in gaming are all here. Now it remains to be seen how they will be put to use. ☒

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